

Green Paper 05 — Commons, Trust, and Local Stewardship

Green Papers: Notes Toward Planetary Guardianship

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Abstract

This paper explores stewardship as a social and institutional capability. “Commons” are not only resources; they are relationships and governance forms: ways of holding shared value without collapsing into either privatization or neglect.

1. Why commons matter now

Planetary constraint forces renewed attention to shared goods: water, soil, air, housing, infrastructures of care, public space, and the conditions for local survival.

2. Trust as governance infrastructure

Trust is often treated as an emotion or a cultural trait. But it also functions as infrastructure: it reduces transaction costs, makes cooperation possible, and allows disagreement without collapse.

3. Stewardship: responsibility that can be carried

Stewardship is a form of responsibility that relates to continuity. It is less about control and more about maintenance, care, and guardianship.

4. Commons governance is not “no rules”

A common misunderstanding is that commons governance means openness without structure. In practice, commons require rules—often more subtle and relational than state law or market contracts.

5. The local scale: small enough to repair

Many governance failures happen because systems become too abstract to remain connected to lived reality.

6. Planetary guardianship as commons practice

Planetary guardianship is not only global governance. It also requires commons competence: the everyday ability to coordinate, maintain, and protect shared conditions of life.

Closing questions

- Which shared resources are becoming commons again under constraint?
- Where is trust being depleted faster than it can be repaired?
- What forms of local governance remain viable under pressure?
- How do we protect stewardship from burnout and moralization?
- What institutional designs support commons without crushing them?

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